Esnaen Macaumbang "Teng" Catong

Dr. Esnaen Macaumbang "Teng" Catong is a Filipino academic, government official, athlete, and social entrepreneur from Pagadian City, Zamboanga del Sur. He currently serves as **Undersecretary** and **Deputy Director-General (DDG)** of the National Anti-Poverty Commission (NAPC) under the Office of the President, a post he has held since April 2024. He is a humble member of the Iranun royal nobles of Illana Bay and the Moro Gulf, and his career spans youth and student leadership, university administration, athletics, defense and security advisory work, and national anti-poverty governance.

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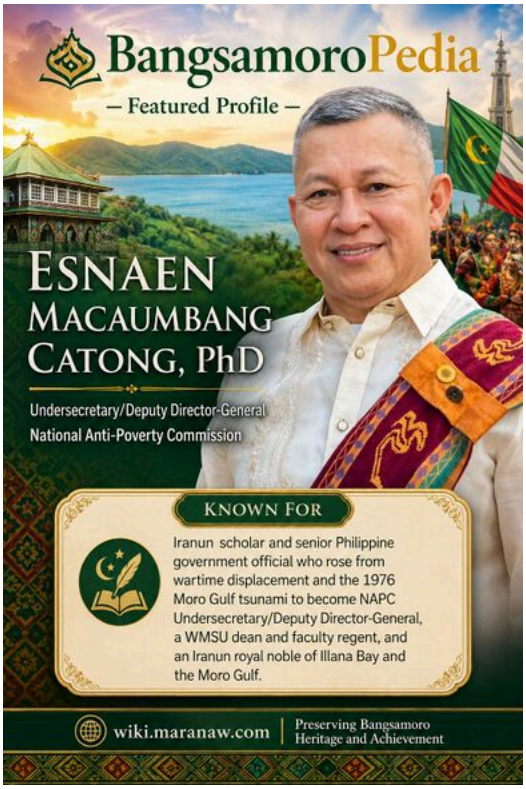
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Early Life

Catong was born and raised in Pagadian City, Zamboanga del Sur, in southwestern Mindanao. His childhood was shaped by two defining experiences of adversity in the 1970s.

During the height of the Moro conflict, Catong and his family lived as bakwits, or internally displaced persons, fleeing volatile crossfires in the region. That experience rooted his lifelong dedication to marginalized communities.

Esnaen Macaumbang Catong, PhD



Title

Undersecretary and Deputy Director-General, National Anti-Poverty Commission

Other Names

"Teng" Catong

Born

Pagadian City, Zamboanga del Sur, Philippines

Ethnicity

Iranun

Education

Pagadian City Pilot School; Zamboanga del Sur School of Arts and Trades (ZSSAT); Western Mindanao State University (BA Political Science, Bachelor of Laws); University of the Philippines Diliman (MA History, cognate in Political Science; PhD coursework in History, cognate in Political Science); University of the Philippines Los Baños (PhD

On August 17, 1976, an 8.1 magnitude earthquake struck the Moro Gulf and triggered a catastrophic tsunami that devastated the coastlines of Pagadian City. Catong survived the disaster, an ordeal that permanently shaped his later focus on institutional crisis management and humanitarian intervention.

To help his family recover from the economic toll of war and disaster, Catong worked as a manual farmer, tilling the land while making his way through school.

Education

Catong completed his early schooling at Pagadian City Pilot School before moving on to the Zamboanga del Sur School of Arts and Trades (ZSSAT). He pursued higher education at Western Mindanao State University (WMSU), where he earned his Bachelor of Arts in Political Science and later his Bachelor of Laws at the WMSU College of Law, while also teaching political science, history, and research and development courses.

He went on to complete advanced postgraduate and doctoral coursework at the University of the Philippines. He earned a Master of Arts in History, with a cognate in Political Science, and completed all academic requirements for a PhD in History, cognate in Political Science, short of the dissertation, in 2013. He has since gone on to successfully pass the final examination, the dissertation final defense, for his PhD in Development Studies, major in Agrarian and Rural Development, with cognates in Strategic Planning and Public Policy, and Sociology, at the UP Los Baños College of Public Affairs and Development. His dissertation, titled *Implications of the Philippine Rice Trade Policy on the Political and Socioeconomic Development in Western Mindanao, Philippines*, was successfully defended on April 28, 2026.

Development Studies, Agrarian and Rural Development Studies, cognates in Strategic Planning and Public Policy, and Sociology)

Occupation

Government official, professor, political scientist, historian, social entrepreneur, athlete

Years Active

1992 to present

Known For

Trailblazing the Magna Carta of the Poor Local Poverty Reduction Action Plan (MCP-LPRAP)

Notability

Iranun scholar and senior Philippine government official who rose from wartime displacement and the 1976 Moro Gulf tsunami to become NAPC Deputy Director-General, a WMSU dean and faculty regent, and an Iranun royal noble of Illana Bay and the Moro Gulf

Known For

Trailblazing the nationwide rollout of RA 11291 (Magna Carta of the Poor) through MCP-LPRAP orientation seminars, championship-level lawn tennis, table tennis, and golf, and humanitarian relief work during the 2013 Zamboanga Siege, the COVID-19 pandemic, and Typhoon Odette

His academic footprint spans both UP Diliman and UP Los Baños, covering History, Political Science, Public Policy, Strategic Planning, Sociology, and Development Studies.

Fellowships

Catong was awarded the DAP-EDPS-Dean Flagship Program and the Rockefeller Research Fellowship, tracking international public policy, national policies on education and peace-building, and developmental socioeconomics.

He attended the first of two batches of the Executive Development Flagship Programme for SUCs Deans at the Development Academy of the Philippines (DAP), where his institutional research paper focused on steering state universities toward becoming Centers of Excellence in Conflict Resolution and Social Development, in 2014.

He also won the Asia Research Fellowship Programme for Young Muslim Scholars in Bangkok, Thailand, under the auspices of the Asia Resource Foundation and the Rockefeller Foundation, based in New York. The initial capitalization for his business ventures in Western Mindanao came from his research grants and fellowships, and the profits from his garments and food businesses went on to sustain two decades of his humanitarian activities.

Youth, Student, and Faculty Leadership

Grassroots and Student Governance

Catong's public service career began at the grassroots level. He served as the first Sangguniang Kabataan (SK) Chairman of Barangay Tiguma in Pagadian City and an ex officio member of the Barangay Council, from 1992 to 1996, known for his clear stance on good governance and anti-corruption. During his term, he ran two notable programs: the "Barangay Clean and Green Program," through which thousands of trees were planted by in-and-out-of-school youth in vacant spaces, and the "Adopt a Farm for the Youth Program."

In 1991, Catong served as President of the Supreme Student Government at ZSSAT, the first Muslim student to hold that position in the school's 45-year history at that time. He graduated with academic honors and received several distinctions: the Oration and Elocution Award as National Champion, the Most Outstanding Leadership Award as SSG President and three-term Senator, finalist status in the Search for the 10 Most Outstanding Boy Scouts of the Philippines as National Awardee representing Region IX, and the Athletics Award as Table Tennis Singles Division Champion in Pagadian City and Regional Player at WMRAA. His alma mater later honored him with the Most Outstanding Alumnus Plaque of Recognition in 2022 and the Most Distinguished Alumni Award in 2026.

While studying at the WMSU College of Law, Catong was overwhelmingly elected President of the University Student Council, where he successfully countered proposed tuition hikes through strategic diplomacy and helped keep the university's main campus and external studies units peaceful throughout his term, from 1997 to 1998.

Following the passage of Republic Act No. 8292, the Higher Education Modernization Act, Catong made history as the first Student Regent on the WMSU Board of Regents, embedding student rights directly into the university's highest policymaking body during the same 1997 to 1998 period.

In 2004, he was an active member and co-editor of the CSSP-UP Diliman Graduate Students Association Editorial Board, which served as a platform for further research engagements and fellowships at home and abroad.

Institutional Academic Leadership

Catong rose through the academic ranks at WMSU, from Instructor to Assistant Professor to Associate Professor, eventually becoming a full-fledged, state-accredited Professor, while holding several high-level administrative posts.

As Chairperson of the Department of Political Science, he revised the Political Science curriculum and grew the department from a single section to three full sections. He positioned the department as a vibrant partner of the university and of underprivileged communities through research and development programs across Western Mindanao, leading a university research team that studied the region's socioeconomic development. The resulting paper, the *Multi-Stakeholder Profiling of the Socioeconomic Development of Western Mindanao*, was presented to foreign funding institutions, the Philippine Economic Team, and the Union of Local Authorities in the Philippines at a national conference sponsored by SEAMEO-INNOTECH at UP Diliman in 2008.

As Chairperson of the Graduate School for Social Sciences, Catong helped grow enrollment in the graduate program by supporting the university's vertical articulation policy. He authored the Faculty Development Program (FDP) in the Board of Regents, which required professors to be capacitated and to teach within their fields of specialization. He argued before the Academic Council and Board of Regents that educators need to be capacitated and vertically articulated to properly serve the communities they work for, reasoning that educators cannot give what they do not know, much less share something they do not know about.

As Dean of the College of Social Sciences, Catong chaired the university's committee for conflict resolution and social development during the 2013 Zamboanga Siege, which displaced five Muslim-dominated urban barangays in Zamboanga City. He coordinated post-war trauma engagements and humanitarian extension services. He was recalled to WMSU to become its youngest College of Social Sciences Dean, leaving UP Diliman before finishing his History PhD dissertation in order to serve the victims of the siege. While serving as dean during the post-war period, he attended the Development Academy of the Philippines as part of the Flagship Executive Development Fellowship Program for SUCs from 2013 to 2014.

Elected President of the WMSU Faculty Union, Catong returned to the Board of Regents as the youngest Faculty Regent in the Philippines, spending years advocating for institutional transparency, collective bargaining rights, and the welfare of teachers and employees. Working with key stakeholders, he helped pioneer a scrap-and-build mechanism at the Board of Regents, the highest policy and governing body of WMSU, the oldest academic institution in Mindanao, founded by the Americans in 1904 as the old Normal School and later transformed into Western Mindanao State University through Presidential Decree 1427 under President Ferdinand E. Marcos Sr. This mechanism created hundreds of new plantilla items for the teaching force, in line with public policy and the accounting and auditing rules of the Department of Budget and Management and the Commission on Audit, and the model was eventually adopted across the Philippine bureaucracy nationwide, from 2008 to 2010. It was during this period that Catong took his first leave of absence to perform Hajj and Umrah.

During his thirteen years at the College of Social Sciences of UP Diliman, Catong personally mentored students Ian Dominic M. Oriño, Alvin Rex Magbanua Lucero, and Nicolo Mel Nich Carb Carballo, who became part of the National Champion team in the SY 2009-2010 Quiz Bowl covering History, Geography, Economics, and Political Science, held at the Philippine Normal University Social Hall. These three mentees went on to become a practicing lawyer, the Zamboanga City Director of the Department of the Interior and Local Government (DILG), and a Lingkod Bayan at the Department of Environment and Natural Resources of Region IX, respectively.

He also served as a Professorial Lecturer at the Philippine Public Safety College (PPSC), teaching strategic governance, public policy, and national safety frameworks to senior law enforcement, jail, and fire safety administrators through the Officers Senior Executive Course (OSEC) and the Master's in Public Safety Administration (MPSA) programs.

Athletic Career

Catong is an accomplished and self-described "science-based" athlete with championship credentials in two demanding sports.

In lawn tennis, he competed across regional and institutional athletic meets, earning a reputation as a strong competitor and advocating for sports programs as a vehicle for youth development and community peace-building.

In golf, Catong is known for his strategic precision on the green and has used the sport as a networking platform connecting academic, corporate, and government leaders. In 2022, he ranked first in the Qualifying Rounds for admission and accreditation as a Teaching Golf Professional under the Games and Amusement Board (GAB) and the PGA of the Philippines (PGAP).

He is also a Class A competitor in table tennis.

Strategic Leadership in Peace, Security, and Regional Development

National Security and Defense Advisory Roles

Catong has served as a civilian advisor to the Philippine armed services. He was a key member of the Regional Advisory Group for Police Transformation and Development (RAGPTD) in Police Regional Office 9 (Zamboanga Peninsula), guiding structural reforms, transparency initiatives, and community-oriented policing under the PNP P.A.T.R.O.L. Plan 2030.

He was also appointed to the Multi-Stakeholder Advisory Board of the Philippine Air Force's Air Combat Command, where he served as Vice Chair for Command and Control and concurrently as Chairperson of the Policy and Governance Committee from 2021 to 2025, working to align defense operations and air combat policy with good governance and national security mandates.

Socio-Political Analysis and Regional Peace

Catong has served as a socio-political media analyst for ABS-CBN's TV Patrol Chavacano and the ABS-CBN News Channel (ANC), offering analysis on national security, the National ID System, federalism, and the State of the Nation Addresses of three Philippine presidents.

He pioneered academic research on using cultural paradigms for peace-building, particularly through his work on optimizing Maratabat, the Maranao concept of pride and honor, as a localized framework for rebuilding community resilience after the 2017 Marawi Siege.

His scholarship on *Philippines-Saudi Arabia Relations, 1968-1998: A Diplomatic History*, along with his advocacy for an "Active Three-O Diplomacy," helped shape frameworks for labor migration, energy security, and human rights. His peace paradigms have been shared across Southeast Asian academic and policy forums, aligning local Mindanao peace initiatives with the broader goals of the ASEAN Socio-Cultural Community.

In 2005, he represented the Philippines and the NAPC-Office of the President at the 4th International Conference on Governance and Development (ICGD4) in Bangkok, Thailand, presenting research on the Magna Carta of the Poor as a policy framework for sustainable development.

National Anti-Poverty Governance

Catong served as Regional President of the Partido Federal ng Pilipinas (PFP) and as a campaign organizer and strategist in the Zamboanga Peninsula during the 2022 national elections, which resulted in a 59.81 percent victory for President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. Following this, he was appointed by President Marcos to the National Anti-Poverty Commission (NAPC) as Deputy Director-General with the rank of Undersecretary in 2024, overseeing the Local Affairs Coordinating and Monitoring Service (NAPC-LACMS) from April 22, 2024 to January 27, 2026.

Under his leadership, NAPC-LACMS conducted a nationwide orientation seminar rollout covering all municipalities, cities, and provinces in the country for the full implementation of Republic Act No. 11291, the Magna Carta of the Poor. This effort produced the South Cotabato Provincial Poverty Reduction Action Plan (PPRAP), the first completed among the country's 82 provinces, developed under the leadership of League of Provinces of the Philippines President and South Cotabato Governor Reynaldo Sucayan Tamayo Jr., who also serves as NAPC Vice-Chairman for the Government Sector.

As Undersecretary, Catong serves as a premiere Resource Speaker on Public Policy and Governance for the DILG Local Government Academy (LGA), where he addresses newly elected and reelected local officials nationwide, including governors, vice-governors, mayors, vice-mayors, and provincial, city, and municipal legislators. Through this platform, he became the primary trailblazer of the Magna Carta of the Poor Local Poverty Reduction Action Plan (MCP-LPRAP), conducting briefing sessions that guide local officials in designing, funding, and legally executing local budgets that guarantee the five fundamental rights of the poor: food, work, education, housing, and health.

Entrepreneurial and Humanitarian Work

Catong is the sole proprietor of Teng's Grill-Zamboanga and was formerly the proprietor of SKUL Garments & Printing Specialist. He converted his business assets into humanitarian logistics during three major crises.

The Zamboanga Siege (2013)

When the 2013 Zamboanga Siege displaced over 100,000 residents, Catong converted his restaurant into an emergency kitchen, becoming the largest private donor of freshly cooked hot meals delivered directly to evacuation clusters. He was featured by former Vice-President and Magandang Gabi Bayan host Noli de Castro for delivering 28,000 halal food packs, twice daily and free of charge, over nine days. He went on to co-design an organized food production and distribution system for the 21-day urban conflict together with then-DSWD Secretary Dinky Soliman, with the support of Assistant Secretary Romo and Director Riduan of DSWD-IX, and his golfing buddies who served as commanders across the PNP and AFP.

As sole proprietor of his garments and printing business, he donated all finished and unfinished school uniforms intended for delivery to 17 schools across ZamPen-BaSulTa as sadakah to war victims. White cotton cloth originally meant for school and sports uniforms was likewise given as sadakah, used for burial requirements for Muslims who died during the war and in evacuation shelters, including the Zamboanga Sports Complex. He also provided his two vehicles free of charge for burial transport for as long as they remained serviceable.

The remaining proceeds from his garments and printing business went toward rebuilding houses of worship, masjids, Catholic churches, and Christian chapels destroyed at ground zero, a gesture meant to show that the people of Zamboanga cared for humanity regardless of faith. He eventually retired SKUL Garments & Printing Specialist after exhausting its resources in service of the relief effort. To sustain ongoing humanitarian work, particularly a university-led food pantry, he personally donated about 50 sacks of rice through Teng's Grill-Zamboanga as part of the "Building Back Better Zamboanga" effort.

The COVID-19 Pandemic (2020)

During the pandemic, Teng's Grill mobilized to feed medical and security frontliners. To protect rural livelihoods, Catong bypassed failing commercial markets and bought food directly from isolated farmers and fisherfolk, using the supplies to feed urban poor communities and support local community pantries. He worked alongside health and social workers and several military officers based in Western Mindanao at the time.

Typhoon Odette in Dinagat Islands (2021)

Following the devastation of Super Typhoon Odette, Catong funded and organized, with a reliable friend, an independent, cross-regional maritime relief operation from Zamboanga, delivering food and survival packs directly to isolated coastal communities in the Dinagat Islands. At the time, the province was led by Governor Arlene

"Kaka" Bag-ao, with Nilo P. Demerey Jr. serving as Vice-Governor before later becoming Governor himself. The operation was the first to deliver potable water and food supplies from mainland Mindanao to the islands, and was made possible with the cooperation of the Joint Task Force Sambisig and the support of a friend and fellow golfer from the Philippine Navy.

Languages

Catong speaks and writes English, Spanish, Filipino, and Cebuano, and is also fluent in Tausug, Yakan, M'ranao, Tausaraya, Maguindanaon, Iranun, Chavacano, and Hiligaynon-Karay-a/Ilonggo. He is currently learning Arabic and Bahasa.

Awards and Recognition

During the 57th Founding Anniversary Celebration of Pagadian City (Araw ng Pagadian City), Catong received the 2026 Most Outstanding Pagadianon Award in Public Service, the highest accolade given to the city's distinguished bona fide inhabitants.

See Also

- National Anti-Poverty Commission
- Western Mindanao State University
- Magna Carta of the Poor
- Iranun people
- Zamboanga Siege

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